



A painted stucco of the Moche's most important god, Al Apaec, who is often depicted with the fangs of a snake.

widely throughout the Mediterranean.

Barely had the Parthian War ended than the **Marcomannic War** began. In early 167, a group of Germanic warriors from the **Langobardi** and **Obii** tribes crossed the Danube to attack the Roman province of Pannonia. They were pushed back fairly easily, but in spring 168 Marcus Aurelius resolved to visit the region to assess the situation. Two more Germanic tribes, the **Marcomanni** and **Quadi** were threatening to force their way across the frontier unless they were admitted to settle in the empire, but Marcus's presence deterred them. However, the expedition was cut short by the death of Lucius Verus from plague in early 169. Marcus returned to Italy, but was back in Pannonia later in the year to launch a **massive offensive** across the Danube. It was a disaster, with the Romans suffering around 20,000 dead and the Marcomanni and Quadi pouring into Italy, where they laid siege to Aquileia. Far from providing an easy victory for Marcus, the war dragged on for another 10 years.

In **China**, the **eunuch faction** at court had become increasingly powerful and had even engineered the murder of the emperor Shaodi in 125. Under **Emperor Huandi** (146–68) a series of natural disasters weakened the authority



Marcus Aurelius

This statue shows Marcus Aurelius adopting a pose of victory, something he claimed but never quite achieved in his Marcomannic Wars.

of the central government, and the emperor relinquished active control of government to the eunuchs. In 168, an attempt by **Dou Xian**, regent for the 12-year-old emperor **Lingdi** (r. 168–89), to have the eunuchs massacred failed—the plot was betrayed and Dou Xian was forced to commit suicide. Several hundred of Dou Xian's supporters were executed and, with its enemies now dead, the eunuch faction was able to exercise power almost unopposed.

THE MOCHE CULTURE EMERGED ON THE COAST OF NORTHERN PERU between 100 and 200. From their bases in the Peruvian valleys of Moche, Chicama, and Virú, these people spread to dominate almost the whole northern coastline. A warlike people, they sacrificed those whom they captured to their deities, including **Al Apaec** ("the decapitator"). They were skilled workers in gold and their pottery has an extraordinarily realistic quality.

The **Roman Empire** was in **crisis** in 170—the Marcomanni and Quadi had occupied parts of northern Italy, and an invasion by the **lazyges** and **Costobocci** had overrun large parts of the Balkans. The Romans trapped the **Marcomanni** as they returned across the Danube and killed many of them. The **Quadi** sued for peace later in 171, but the Marcomanni remained recalcitrant, forcing a **new offensive** in 172. The forces of Marcus Aurelius could never quite strike the killer blow, and by 175 the war had reached a **stalemate**.

In May that year, rumors that Marcus Aurelius

Moche stirrup jar

This jar has a typical Moche "stirrup" attached to the back of it. The realism of the paddling figure is characteristic of the culture's ceramics.

THE GERMANIC TRIBES

The Romans had faced Germanic tribes ever since they had reached the Rhine at the time of Julius Caesar. German groups across the Danube, such as the Quadi and Marcomanni, proved troublesome in the 2nd century, but by the late 3rd century new and more dangerous confederations of Germanic tribes arose, such as the Franks, Alamanns, and Goths, who overran much of the Roman Empire by the mid-5th century.

had died while on campaign prompted a revolt by **Avidius Cassius**, the governor of Syria. Avidius was **declared emperor** in Egypt, and received support in Arabia, as well as in his own province of Syria. Critically, however, he failed to secure the support of **Martius Verus**, the

governor of Cappadocia, whom he had fought alongside during the Parthian War.

As Martius's army approached, the loyalty of the usurper's troops wavered, and in July **Avidius Cassius was murdered** by a disaffected centurion, putting an end to his short-lived but dangerous rebellion. There were suggestions that Marcus's wife **Faustina** encouraged Avidius, as she feared for her husband's health and worried her own son Commodus was unfit to rule.

Free from the distraction of Avidius's revolt, Marcus Aurelius returned to the Danube in 177. In the winter of 179–80, the **Roman army** occupied positions deep across the Danube, and it looked as if Marcus might be able to create two new Roman provinces—Marcomannia and Samartia. However, Marcus was old and tired—he died in March 180. His son **Commodus** brought the war to a rapid conclusion, allowing him to return to Rome.

